

How to Focus Your Attention

Focusing your attention requires your brain to process specific information. Learning how to accomplish this in a world where there are plenty of distractions is crucial to allow you to learn, understand, and function properly.

Attention is a limited resource, and focusing it has to be carefully managed if you are to be able to limit distractions and concentrate on specific tasks. The ability to focus attention varies between people. It is influenced by both your interest in the task at hand and the number of distractions that you encounter. If you are really interested in something, you may not even notice other distractions that occur in the environment around you. This is simply because it is easier to focus your attention on something if you are engaged with it. So how can you increase your ability to focus your attention?

Distractions, distractions, distractions

Focusing your attention involves concentrating on something specific, while tuning out both

external and internal distractions. While you are reading this book, you will hopefully be focusing your attention on the words written in the text. However, your brain will be bombarded with a range of distractions. These can emanate from a variety of external sources. For example, the television may be on in the background or people may be having a conversation around you.

You might also be faced with internal distractions. Hunger may motivate you to start thinking about what you are having for dinner. You might suddenly remember an important task that had slipped your mind. These types of internal thoughts are driven by an area of the brain called the medial prefrontal cortex (see pp.30–31), which is associated with decision-making, emotional

responses, and the retrieval of long-term memories.

Research suggests that once your attention is distracted from completing a task, it can take an average of 25 minutes to return to the original exercise. So the next time you are being distracted, try one of the following to focus your attention:

- **Keep potential distractions away. Turn off any electronic devices and move to a quiet place.**
- **If the task at hand is unavoidably monotonous, it can help to remind yourself why you are doing it.**
- **Imagine the sense of accomplishment you will feel upon completing the task. This can provide additional motivation.**
- **Gradually and slowly increase the time that you try to focus your attention. This can improve your attentional focus.**